



Last hurrah: This may be the last Ashes for Australia's old guard, consisting of the likes of Josh Hazlewood, Mitchell Starc and Nathan Lyon.

time for Root to snap his century jinx on his fourth Test tour down under.

Flatter pitches back home have been central to England's ability to liberate its batters, and Australia's increasingly livelier surfaces will present a litmus test for Bazball.

Batting averages here have dipped to 28.63 in the last five years, down from 36.49 between 2015 and 2019.

Throw the pace quartet of Starc, Hazlewood, Boland and Cummins into the mix, and it is a perfect storm for England's top seven, three of whom — Duckett, Brook and Jamie Smith — are on their first tour down under. The lack of experience in Australian climes percolates to the touring party's bowling unit, too, with Mark Wood being the exception. The express pacer's 17 wickets at 26.64 in the last Ashes in Australia were England's silver lining in 2021-22, but his proclivity for injury will worry Stokes, whose bowling will also be vital. Jofra Archer's ability to conjure

easy hostility could be a point of difference.

England and Australia are the pacesetters in the Bazball era. They lead the world's run-rate charts in Test cricket, though they themselves are almost a whole run apart. The devil is in the details. England has upended one of Test cricket's oldest doctrines — respecting the 'good' balls — with stunning consistency. The Bazball upheaval has seen English batters average 28.26 and score at 3.17 runs per over against the good-length deliveries by fast bowlers on a probing off-stump line or just outside it, blazing ahead in both metrics amongst their contemporaries.

The drawn 2-2 Ashes stalemate in 2023 was proof that Stokes' men won't relent, though the recent deadlock against India betrayed a refinement of aggression. An Ashes win, almost 15 years in the making, would be the ultimate vindication.

Test batting averages and run rates against good-length deliveries on and outside off stump by fast bowlers in the Bazball era (since 2022)

